Choices

By James McLindon

INTRODUCTION

According to the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, in 2020 student loan debt reached an all-time high, nearly $1.6 trillion among more than 40 million Americans, making the Department of Education the country's biggest consumer lender. Furthermore, according to the U.S. Department of Education, about 1 in every 5 borrowers are in default.

Student loan debt is out of control. Heck, there's even a television trivia game show called Paid Off with Michael Torpey where the winner has the chance to win the sum of their student debt in cash. We have entered the theatre of the absurd . . . but James McLindon in his short play Choices takes it one step further.

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(Pg 39 – 46) *A modest living room (think poor graduate student), the present. The PROSPECTIVE CLIENT sits at her/his coffee (or dining room) table across from the DEBT COUNSELOR, who has the calmness and patience of a funeral home director for the most part, there to help and alert to steer clear of any heaviness with a ready euphemism. All of that is underlaid with an enthusiastic love of her/his product. The PROSPECTIVE CLIENT is a little anxious, really needing this to work. The DEBT COUNSELOR has been waiting for the PROSPECTIVE CLIENT to finish reading a pamphlet. The PROSPECTIVE CLIENT now looks up, perplexed.*

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I'm sorry, I just don't get it.

DEBT COUNSELOR: It's pretty simple. It's just ... disruptive.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: No, I know, it sounds simple ....

DEBT COUNSELOR: Think of it as a choice. We're all about choices. You can choose this. Or not.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: No, no, I want to choose this, believe me. I feel like I'm on a hamster wheel just trying to keep up with the payments, but ... this just seems too good to be true.

DEBT COUNSELOR: That's often what disruption looks like. Remember all the things you used to have to pay to read, like newspapers, magazines? Now you get them on-line

for free. We're disrupting the entire debt consolidation industry, sort of like that.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Okay, but ... I still don't get it.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Tell me what you don't get.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: So, you pay off my student loans...

DEBT COUNSELOR: Your crushing student loans.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Yes, thank you, my 247,000 dollars in student loans, and all I have to do is pay you seventy-two dollars a month?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Yes.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: For twenty years.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Yes.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: And that's it. That's all I ever have to pay you.

DEBT COUNSELOR: That's all you ever have to pay us. *(The PROSPECTIVE CLIENT calculates in her/his head.)*

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Okay, so I'm not really great at math, but I think that's only, like, $170,000?

DEBT COUNSELOR: It's actually about $17,000.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Only 17,000 dollars!? Okay, now I don't get this even more.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Tell me what you don't get.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: What don't I...? You give me 247,000 dollars to pay off my debt today and all I have to give you is 17,000 dollars over twenty years?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Right. Mainly to keep you focused.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: So you lose money.

DEBT COUNSELOR: No ...

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Yeah, you lose money. Nobody sets up a business to lose money, unless they're, like, money laundering or something. Wait, are you guys money laundering?

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DEBT COUNSELOR: No.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: What are you doing?

DEBT COUNSELOR: We're providing choices. *(Pause.)* I think maybe you skipped footnote seven.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I didn't read the footnotes.

DEBT COUNSELOR: You should read the footnotes.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I never do.

DEBT COUNSELOR: You always should.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Okay, fine, what does footnote seven say?

DEBT COUNSELOR: It answers this question.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: About whether you're money laundering?

DEBT COUNSELOR: About how we get paid. *(Beat.)*

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: So how do you? I mean, after I finish my payments you'll be short about 230,000 dollars. Not to mention any interest. So where do you get the rest (from) ... ? Oh, there're a bunch of hidden fees, aren't there?

DEBT COUNSELOR: There are no fees at all.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Then c'mon, how do you get your money back from me?

DEBT COUNSELOR: We don't get it back from you.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: You don't?

DEBT COUNSELOR: We don't. *(Pause.)* From you.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Who do you get it back from?

DEBT COUNSELOR: The insurance company.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: What insurance company?

DEBT COUNSELOR: You should really read footnote seven ...

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Just tell me, what insurance company!?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Your insurance company.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Why would my car insurance company pay you?

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DEBT COUNSELOR: Not your car insurance company.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Well, that's the only insurance I have. I sure don't have homeowners because you can't afford to buy a house when you owe $247,000 ...

DEBT COUNSELOR: Your life insurance company. *(Beat.)*

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I don't have life insurance.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Footnote seven.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I have to get life insurance?

DEBT COUNSELOR: We pay for it.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: What good does life insurance do anyone?

DEBT COUNSELOR: It depends.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Unless I die.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Read footnote seven.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Oh my God. You've looked at my DNA! You have, you totally have! That DNA company that said I was 2.3% Neanderthal sold you my data and you looked at it and you know I have a genetic abnormality and I'm going to die young, so that's how you ... What are you writing down?

DEBT COUNSELOR: No, please, go on, that's a really interesting business model.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Stop it! That's not your business model?

DEBT COUNSELOR: No, but it's pretty good though. Way disruptive.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: So I'm not going to die in the next twenty years?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Well, how would I know that?

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: There's no DNA stuff in your file on me?

DEBT COUNSELOR: All we have is what you gave us.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: *(Exhaling.)* I'm not going to die young.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Well, not in the next twenty years. As far as I know.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Do you qualify everything you say?

DEBT COUNSELOR: When it needs to be. Because we're totally honest. With our clients.

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PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: So how do you make money from my life insurance?

DEBT COUNSELOR: How does anyone make money from life insurance?

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Somebody has to die. *(Pause.)* But you just said I wouldn't!

DEBT COUNSELOR: I said I don't know anything about your DNA. Or your health at all for that matter. We don't worry about that. Please. Read footnote seven. *(PROSPECTIVE CLIENT stares at DEBT COUNSELOR, who stares back. A beat.)* Please.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Okay, fine. *(PROSPECTIVE CLIENT returns to reading the pamphlet. Then PROSPECTIVE CLIENT looks up at DEBT COUNSELOR, stunned.)* Oh my god!

DEBT COUNSELOR: *(Excited for the first time.)* I know, right!? The first time I read it, I was like, Whaaaaat!? But the more you think about it, the more genius it is. Dis! Effing! Ruption! Amiright!? *(Catching himself, quieting.)* Sorry. I just love this product so much.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: I'm not going to agree to this! Does anyone ever agree to this?

DEBT COUNSELOR: No. (Pause.) Not at first. But then they think about it. And they think, well, when I took out my crushing student loans, I knew that they would impact my life. Severely impact my life. For a whole lot of my life. Decades and decades. And see, that's all this is really. You just assumed that the impact would be frontloaded. And all we do is ... backload it for you.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Me dying at *(whatever age is about twenty years older than actor)* in twenty years, that's what you call "severely impacting" my life?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Well, it seems severe to me.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: No, it's severe, it's very severe!

DEBT COUNSELOR: Yes. But. What a much better life it will have been. These next twenty years anyway. Which, after all, is your prime.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: How do you ... you know...do it?

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DEBT COUNSELOR: Do what?

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Make it so you get to, you know, collect. *(Pause.)*

DEBT COUNSELOR: Before we get into the details, I think it's best that you get comfortable with the concept (first) ...

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: How!?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Well, it's up to you. See? Choices. Most people opt to handle matters themselves. We'll give you some recommendations and how-tos in the next brochure it's under "Self-Termination." A lot of people, though, find they're too ... squeamish? for Self-Term when push comes to shove and for them we offer Appointment Service. You know how you can schedule a caesarian these days? Well, this is sort of ...

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: The exact opposite.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Yes. The App Serv team is excellent, guaranteed painless and they can make anything look like an accident. And finally, there are some people who are squeamish, but who also find that having an actual appointment makes them ...

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Freaking terrified?

DEBT COUNSELOR: Mmm, anxious. For them we offer a third approach, a service where you just go about your business and we ... take it from there. That one's called Dealer's Choice. *(Pause.)* You don't have to decide that now.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: A lot of people must just run when their time is up.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Oh, people are surprisingly ethical about it. Also, we implant a chip that sends us your GPS coordinates.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: What if I dig the chip out?

DEBT COUNSELOR: We don't put it anywhere too ... accessible? And if you did get it out, we always have the Recovery Team.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: The chips are that valuable?

DEBT COUNSELOR: You're that valuable. You know how the Coast Guard has rescue and

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recovery units. This is more recovery and ... not rescue. *(Beat.)* You can always say no. We're all about choices. *(Suddenly, the DEBT COUNSELOR has an edge, a subtle darkness. Maybe there's a lighting change for his/her next speech.)* Quantity or quality. You can live in your run-down studio apartment if you want. With a roommate. And drive a fifteen-year-old beater. And eat ramen noodles. And never take a decent vacation. And waste a lot of your life living on the shoulder of poverty.

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Or I can have only twenty years left.

DEBT COUNSELOR: Twenty debt-free years to keep and spend your money. To travel, buy a house, have a life, whatever that means to you. And do you really want to live longer than that?

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: My parents got to.

DEBT COUNSELOR: But do you want to? With the rising tides of climate change lapping at your ankles and blowing down your little garret. With the last shreds of our democracy fraying before your eyes, while the old-world order collapses. I don't think it's too much to say that the ones who choose to go with us are in many ways the lucky ones. *(Pause; brighter again.)* Hey, it's a big decision, so you take your time, talk to your friends, your family. And if you do choose to go with us, just give me a call. *(The DEBT COUNSELOR hands the PROSPECTIVE CLIENT a card, shakes hands, and begins to leave.)*

PROSPECTIVE CLIENT: Wait. Are ... are you a client? *(The DEBT COUNSELOR turns back, smiles and pulls up his/her shirt.)*

DEBT COUNSELOR: There's my GPS scar. Take a look around on the beach this summer. You'll be surprised. *(Smiling.)* Call me. *(Exits.)*

(The PROSPECTIVE CLIENT looks at the card, snorts in derision, throws it in the trash can, then sits down and thinks for a few moments. She/he picks the trash can up, starts to reach in to remove the card, and then stops. Still holding the can, she/ he looks up, uneasy, thinking.)

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